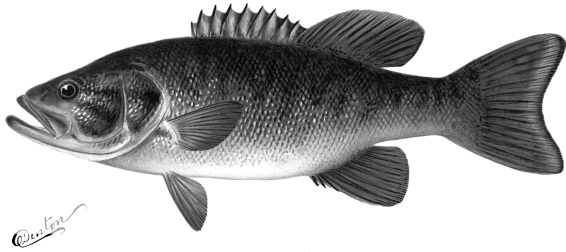


Smallmouth Bass

Micropterus dolomieu

Rock, gravel and hard bottom — Pine Lake & North Lake



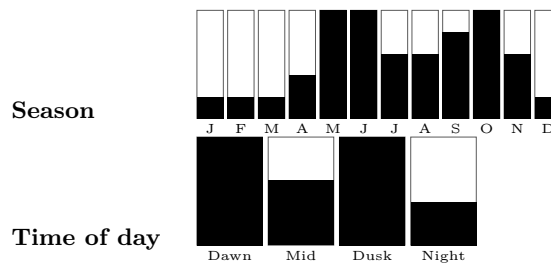
The Small-Mouthed Black Bass — chromolithograph by S.F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart Bronze rather than green, with dark *vertical* bars instead of one horizontal stripe, and a red or orange eye. The upper jaw stops under the eye. The dorsal fin is one continuous fin, not pinched.

Size here 12–17 in typical; 18 in and up is a strong fish. State record 9 lb 1 oz. Pound for pound the hardest-fighting fish in either lake.

Spawn Gravel and rubble in 3–10 ft at 60–65 °F, a little later and deeper than largemouth. Pine Lake's 90% gravel bottom is close to ideal smallmouth habitat.

Eats Crayfish above all, then minnows, perch fry and insect larvae. Match the crayfish and you are most of the way there.



Where

Pine This is a smallmouth lake. Spots **2** (north-east breaks), **3** (east wall), **4** (the mid-lake bar) and **8**. The bar is the best smallmouth spot in the county on a good October morning.

North Spots **3** and **4**. The south-end shoal complex is the equivalent of Pine's bar.

Structure Hard bottom with a fast change in depth. Rock points, gravel bars, rip-rap, boulder fields. If your jig comes back scuffed, you are in the right place.

Season Shallow and aggressive in May–June, deep and moody in July–August, then shallow and violent again in late September and October.

How

Best all-round	A tube jig dragged and hopped on the bottom. It looks exactly like a fleeing crayfish and nothing else is needed most days.
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Deep and finicky Drop-shot with a small minnow-shaped plastic, *see the **drop-shot** sheet*. This is how you fish Pine Lake's east wall in August.

Cold water A suspending jerkbait, worked with long pauses. In 45–55 °F water the pause is the whole presentation.

Live bait A live crayfish or a large leech on a plain hook with one split shot, *see the **split shot sheet***. Deadly and simple.

Line Fluorocarbon on Pine Lake. The water is clear enough that it matters.

The one thing to remember

Smallmouth live where the bottom is hard. Largemouth live where the cover is soft. On the same lake, on the same day, that one distinction sorts almost every spot.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 14 in minimum, 5 per day, open 2 May–7 March. Catch-and-release open all year. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*